negotiations with the United Kingdom, Canada, and European Union were resuscitated, and deals began to be considered with countries such as Oman, Israel, and Bangladesh.

This new flurry of economic diplomacy was not restricted to trade agreements. India joined three out of four pillars of the US-led Indo–Pacific Economic Framework (IPEF) and concluded a supply chain agreement in that format. [51] Strategic and technological cooperation with the European Union was elevated with the creation of an India–EU Trade and Technology Council (TTC). India also began entering into a series of mobility agreements, including with some European countries, that would structure migration from India. Bilateral trade, defence, diplomatic, and technology relationships between India and European countries—including the Nordic, Baltic, Mediterranean, and Central and Eastern European countries—also saw an upswing. A new global rebalance was underway, encapsulated in initiatives such as the Quad, I2U2, IMEC, iCET with the United States, the TTC with the European Union, new security partnerships with countries like the Philippines and Armenia, infrastructure investments in the Indian Ocean and beyond, and technology tie-ups with South Korea and Taiwan. The post-pandemic world was beginning to have some major effects on India's domestic economy and international partnerships.

Regional Turmoil: South and West Asia, 2020–2023

If global developments were transformative after the outbreak of the Covid-19 pandemic, events in South and West Asia proved equally dramatic. In August 2021, the United States decided to withdraw its military from Afghanistan after two decades and began negotiations with the Taliban that included a release of prisoners. While the Afghan government under Ashraf Ghani had been expected to survive a US withdrawal, particularly given investments and years of US-sponsored training for the Afghan National Security Forces (ANSF), the Taliban swiftly swept into all major urban centres in the country. In the chaos that followed, foreigners and Afghans were evacuated out of Hamid Karzai International Airport in Kabul. India